FREE BROCHURE

Dating and Relationships

A plain, practical guide for autistic adults on asking someone out, planning a date, handling a no, and spotting healthy and unhealthy relationships.

WHO IT IS FOR
Autistic adults (18 and over), and the educators and support staff who work with them, including Senior Cycle and LCA teachers.

NCCA STAGE
Adults · Senior Cycle and LCA (educator use)

Easy read

Dating is when two adults spend time together to see if they like each other. Both people must want to. Both people can say no.

How to use this resource

- Read this at your own pace. You can read it with a friend, a family member or a support worker if you want.
- Practise the scripts out loud. Change the words so they sound like you.
- Use the date-planning checklist before every first date.
- Educators: this brochure is for adults aged 18 and over. For younger students, use it to plan teaching, not as a handout.

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Version 1.0 · dating-and-relationships

Is dating for me?

Some autistic adults want a partner. Some do not. Some want a close friend and no romance. Some are not sure yet. All of these are fine. You do not have to date to have a good life, and you are not 'behind' if you have not.

I choose if I want a partner.

I choose when. There is no rush.

Both of us must want it.

Asking someone out

Say it clearly. Say it kindly. Give the person an easy way to say no. A clear ask is better than hints. Most people appreciate it.

Asking someone you know, such as from a club, work or college

I enjoy talking to you. Would you like to get a coffee with me on Saturday?

Asking by message

Hi, I like spending time with you. Would you like to go on a date with me? It is OK to say no.

Asking someone you met on a dating app

I enjoyed our messages. Would you like to meet for a coffee in town? We can pick a quiet place.

If you want to find out if they are interested first

Do you think of me as a friend, or would you like to go on a date?

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Tips

- Ask once. Do not ask the same person again and again.
- Ask in private or by message. Do not ask in front of a group.
- Do not ask someone who has power over you, such as a boss, a tutor or a support worker. That is not safe or fair.

Does the other person like me?

Hints and body language can be hard to read. Nobody can read minds. These signs may mean someone is interested. They are not proof. The only way to be sure is to ask.



Signs they may be interested

They start chats with you. They ask about you. They make plans with you. They say they like spending time with you. They message you often.

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Signs they may not be interested

They say no or 'not now'. They do not reply. They cancel plans. They say 'I just see you as a friend'. They look away or leave.

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Unclear signs

Smiling, being friendly, laughing at your jokes, or saying 'we should hang out'. These can just be kindness.

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If you are unsure

Ask. 'Would you like to go on a date with me, or would you rather stay friends?'

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If unsure, I ask.



If the answer is no, I stop.

Planning a date

A plan helps you to feel calm. Choose a place you know, at a time of day that suits you. Tell the other person what you need. Real friends and partners are glad to know.

My date plan

Who I am meeting: _____

Where (a public place): _____

Date and time: _____

How long I will stay: _____

How I am getting there and home: _____

A quiet backup place nearby: _____

A friend who knows my plan: _____

☐ **Public place.** Meet in a café, a park or a cinema. Not at home, and not in a car.

☐ **Tell a friend** where you are going, who you are meeting and when you will be back. Share your location if you want.

☐ **Phone charged** and money for getting home.

☐ **Sensory plan.** Think about noise, lights, smells, crowds and food. Pick a quiet table. Bring headphones, sunglasses or a fidget if you want. It is OK to say 'It is a bit loud for me. Can we move?'

☐ **Eating.** Look at the menu online first. Choose something you can eat. You do not have to eat if you do not want to.

☐ **Your own transport home.** You are free to leave at any time.

☐ **A way to leave.** 'I am going to go now. It was nice to meet you.' You do not need to give a reason.

What if the answer is no?

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Hearing no can hurt. It is normal to feel sad, angry or embarrassed. A no is about what the other person wants. It does not mean you are not good enough.

They say no

OK. Thank you for telling me.

They say 'Let's stay friends'

OK. I need a little time. I will message you later.

You feel upset

I am going to take a break now. I will talk to you another time.

- Do not ask again, and do not keep messaging or following them. This can frighten people.
- Do something that calms you: a walk, music, your special interest or talking to someone you trust.
- Remind yourself: 'I asked clearly. That was brave.'
- If the sadness is big or lasts a long time, talk to your GP or text 50808 (text HELLO to 50808).

Healthy and unhealthy relationships

In a healthy relationship, both people feel safe, respected and free to be themselves. Look at the lists below. If you see things in the red box, talk to someone you trust.

Healthy

- Kind words and kind actions
- Both of us can say yes or no
- I can see my friends and family
- We talk about problems calmly
- My phone and money are mine
- They respect my sensory needs
- I feel safe and like myself

Unhealthy

- Shouting, name-calling, hitting or threats
- They stop me seeing family or friends
- They check my phone or follow me
- They control my money
- They do not stop when I say no
- They make me afraid or say it is my fault
- I feel scared or small around them

Consent: every time

Consent means both people agree, freely, to something. This applies to kissing, touching, sex and anything else with your body. It also applies to sharing photos.

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Every time

A yes today does not mean yes tomorrow. Ask each time.

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Say it clearly

'Do you want to kiss me?' 'Is this OK?' Use words, not just guesses.

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You can change your mind

You can say stop at any time, even after you said yes.

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No means no

Silence, freezing or being drunk or asleep is not a yes.

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Age of consent

In Ireland, the age of consent to sexual activity is 17.

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Pressure is not consent

If someone keeps asking, threatens, or makes you feel guilty, a yes is not free.

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Practise saying it

You want to check

Is this OK? You can tell me to stop.

You do not want to

No, I do not want to. Please stop.

You are not sure

I am not sure. I need to stop for now.

Someone says no to you

OK. Thank you for telling me.

Notes for adults

- Autistic adults can be as capable of consent as anyone else. Do not assume. Teach consent explicitly, with literal language, scripts and practice, and respect their right to relationships.
- Some autistic people are at higher risk of being pressured or exploited, because of masking, being taught to comply, or not recognising hints. Teach clearly what is and is not OK. Ensure the person knows who to tell, and that they will be believed.
- Educators working with students aged 17 and under: the age of consent is 17. Follow the school's RSE policy and Child Protection Procedures (Designated Liaison Person).
- Support independence. Do not decide for the person who they may love.

Staying healthy

If you have sex, you have the right to look after your health. **sexualwellbeing.ie** is the HSE website. It has clear, free information about contraception, sexually transmitted infections (STIs), testing and where to go. HSE services include free STI testing. A free contraception scheme exists for women and people who can become pregnant; check sexualwellbeing.ie for current eligibility.



I can get tested for STIs. It is a normal health check.



Condoms help to protect against STIs and pregnancy.



My GP can talk to me about sexual health. It is private.

Coercive control is a crime

Coercive control

In Ireland, coercive control is a crime under the Domestic Violence Act 2018. It means a pattern of controlling or frightening behaviour by a partner or former partner. It does not have to include hitting. If you think this is happening to you, you are not alone. It is not your fault, and you can ask for help.

You can ring Women's Aid (1800 341 900), Men's Aid (01 554 3811), the Dublin Rape Crisis Centre (1800 77 88 88) or the Gardaí. In an emergency, ring 112 or 999.

My safety plan

Three people I can tell: _____

A place I can go if I feel unsafe: _____

A number I can ring: _____

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Curriculum links

NCCA and Department of Education alignment

- Senior Cycle SPHE: new specification published 2024, being introduced for fifth years, includes relationships and sexuality learning, including consent, healthy relationships and sexual health. Leaving Certificate Applied: Social Education.
- Junior Cycle SPHE (2023), Strand 3 *Relationships and Sexuality*: for background teaching before Senior Cycle.
- NCCA guidance on RSE for students with special educational needs: teach consent, relationships and sexual health explicitly, with plain language and visual supports.

Universal Design for Learning

Every Autism & Me resource offers more than one way in: pictures and words together, an easy-read line, things to do with your hands, and scripts to practise. Keep the learning aim the same for everyone, and change the route. No diagnosis is needed to use any support in this resource.

Getting support in Ireland

Emergency

112 or 999 — Gardaí, ambulance or fire. Use it if someone is in danger now.

Women's Aid

24-hour freephone helpline: 1800 341 900.

Men's Aid Ireland

Support for men experiencing abuse: 01 554 3811.

Rape Crisis Help

Dublin Rape Crisis Centre national helpline, free and 24 hours: 1800 77 88 88.

HSE Sexual Wellbeing

Free information, free STI testing and free contraception information at sexualwellbeing.ie.

Autism & Me

Questions about this resource or training for your school: contactautismandme@gmail.com · autismandme.ie

If a child tells you something worrying

Stay calm. Listen, and believe them. Do not promise to keep it a secret. Write down what they said in their own words, with the date. Pass it on the same day: in a school, to the Designated Liaison Person (DLP); otherwise to Tusla. If anyone is in immediate danger, call 112 or 999. Follow *Children First: National Guidance for the Protection and Welfare of Children* (2017).

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